

THE COUNCIL OF UN · AN ENCLOSURE, HAND-DELIVERED

An Envelope for Leah

I

Five parts: a note in a plain hand, a word on how the game is played, a word on what the Council is, three doorways to choose between, and a seat interview to be written in and brought back. There is room to write on every page of the last part. Nothing in here is a test.

PART I The Note

Leah, I'm glad you said yes. Every Tuesday, Taxe and a fellow named Ali and I sit down and tell a story together, and there's a chair open for you. You don't need to prepare anything, or read anything, or be good at anything. You just need to show up curious.

Everything you need is in this envelope. Read it front to back, and anything still fuzzy, we'll clear up together before we start Tuesday.

What follows this note is written in the voice of the game itself. Don't work at decoding it — just let it set the mood.

Warmly,
Maxwell

THE WELCOME - ABOARD THE SILVER SURFER

There is a ship called the Silver Surfer, and she is moored wherever water remembers your name. You've a seat aboard her now, which is a stranger sentence than it sounds, and a truer one.

Welcome. The water's been expecting you.

PART II How This Kind of Game Works

You've maybe heard of games played with dice and rulebooks. This isn't quite that. There's no board, no winning, no dice.

What we do is tell a story together, out loud, taking turns. One person — that's me — describes a world and the people in it, and everyone else decides what their own character says and does. When you want your character to try something, you just say so, and we find out together what happens.

Here, the pen is mightier than the die. That's our way of saying we decide things by what makes the best story, not by luck.

You cannot fail at this. You can only add to it.

PART III What Council Is

Our story is set in a far-off city called Atlantis, on the far side of the galaxy, run by a small group of people who make the hard decisions together. That group is the Council, and you're being given a seat on it.

You'll help decide what the city does, who it trusts, and what it risks.

Taxe sits on that Council too.

You don't need to know the history. You'll pick it up as we go — the same way you'd learn any group of friends' inside stories, by being there. Nobody at the table knows everything, and nobody expects you to.

PART IV Three Doorways

Each of these begins the same way: Landis Fishman drew you out of the water and brought you aboard the *Silver Surfer*, and the *Surfer* brought you to Atlantis. They differ in who you were before the water took you.

Pick whichever sounds like someone you'd enjoy being. None of them is a cage — you can say *yes*, *but* to any of it.

DOORWAY THE FIRST

THE OUTSIDER'S CLEAR EYE

The Traveler

Someone from Earth, near enough to our own time, who went into deep water one night and stepped off the *Surfer* into a city at the end of the galaxy. On the Council she is the outsider's clear eye — she asks the obvious questions nobody else dares ask. Taxe becomes the one who explains this new world to her.

DOORWAY THE SECOND

THE PEACEMAKER

The Envoy

Someone drawn from Earth's distant past, long before the modern age. A born diplomat in her own time — a voice that settled disputes and held quarrelsome people together. The water carried her across centuries and stars. On the Council she is the peacemaker, the one who looks for the settlement everyone can live with, and who trusts words over force. Where Taxe leads from the front, the Envoy holds the room; they balance each other rather than compete.

DOORWAY THE THIRD

THE INTUITIVE ONE

The Returned

Someone whose past even she cannot fully name. The water gave her back changed. On the Council she is the intuitive one — she feels things about a choice before she can explain why. There is something in the city's recent history that quietly rhymes with her, though she doesn't know it yet.

PART V

The Seat Interview

Answer these however you like — a word, a paragraph, a doodle in the margin. There are no wrong answers, and you may leave any of them blank. Write straight onto the page; the pages come back to Maxwell as they are.

QUESTION ONE

Which of the three sounded most like someone you'd enjoy being? And if none quite did, describe the one you'd rather have.

☐ THE TRAVELER ☐ THE ENVOY ☐ THE RETURNED ☐ NONE - SEE BELOW

QUESTION TWO

What's her name? Anything you like. It doesn't have to sound like anything in particular.

QUESTION THREE

Where and when was she before the water took her? A country, a century, a city — or just a feeling of a place. As much or as little as you want.

QUESTION FOUR

What was she doing with her life then? Her work, her days, the ordinary shape of it.

QUESTION FIVE

Who did she leave behind, and does she know she left them?

QUESTION SIX

What is she good at that has nothing to do with adventure? A practical skill, a knack, a trade.

QUESTION SEVEN

When people disagree in front of her, what does she do — step in, hold back, take a side, or find the middle?

QUESTION EIGHT

What does she want badly enough that she'd argue for it in a room full of people who outrank her?

QUESTION NINE

What frightens her that she'd rather nobody knew?

QUESTION TEN

She wakes on a ship she doesn't recognise, and a man tells her she has a seat on a council in a city at the far end of the galaxy. What's the first thing out of her mouth?

PART VI Room to Write

Optional, and blank is a perfectly good answer. Questions of your own, a thing you'd like to be true of her, a thing you'd rather never came up at the table, or anything at all that the ten questions didn't have a line for.



Bring this back however it ends up — folded, scribbled, or perfect. It goes on the record as it is.